

10. 'There is no place for failure in your society.' Do you agree?

Key words:

'no place'

- If *failure*, in its various forms, has no place in the society, it is seen as an outcome that is not desirable, and individuals or groups who fail are deemed to be not meeting up to the expectations of society.

'failure'

- A condition of not meeting specific objectives or standards; the opposite of success. It could refer to results one acquire, perhaps a fail grade. It can refer to a mindset one has, i.e. someone who feels defeated by life's challenges and quits trying to overcome them.
- Possible domains in which failure can be discussed includes education, one's financial state, career, sport and social status.

Implications behind the statement in the question

1. There is societal expectation that failure in whatever form it takes can and should be avoided because the Singapore *society's* focus on meritocracy makes *success* inherently celebrated and affirms those who are successful, while those who *fail* are branded a *failure*.
2. Some of the most successful individuals in history might have been shaped by hardship in their lives, developing resilience and gumption in the process of overcoming challenges in their lives but in present day Singapore/another society, failure has no such value.

Suggested stand/thesis:

While failure was, and to some extent, is still looked upon with some amount of disdain by many in the Singapore society due to societal norms and expectations, mindset changes and new circumstances have taken place to allow failure to now have a place in society.

Approach:

Part A. Discuss why failure is seen to generally not be accepted in Singapore by considering circumstances that led to the society's aversion towards failure, and how this aversion manifests

Part B. Show that the Singaporean society is now more open to giving people second chances as we recognise that failure is but a step towards attaining success

Possible Arguments

Part A. Discuss why failure is seen to generally not be accepted in Singapore by considering circumstances that led to the society's aversion towards failure, and how this aversion manifests

1. A 'survival mindset' engendered by the national narrative and internalised by the masses, seems to have led to a constant emphasis on striving to be successful in order to survive, because the failure to do so could mean certain demise for the country and its constituents, which makes this outcome something people will work hard to avoid.

Since its independence, the message that Singapore has to have the resolve to battle challenges posed by its small size and lack of natural resources is constantly drilled into the populace. This national psyche lies at the heart of Singaporeans' constant strive to achieve *excellence* in all their endeavours, be it the individual's studies and careers or the nation's economic performance. While this inspires confidence in foreign investors and generates prosperity for the masses, it makes whoever fails considered to have 'fallen by the wayside'. Today's context of a VUCA world has only worsened the situation, where a tougher environment economically and politically has made it even more necessary that Singaporeans slog to succeed – or at least, not fail.

2. Failure means a loss of face and face is integral to the Asian culture, even in countries that are fairly westernised like Singapore and since one's reputation is at stake, the masses will do their utmost to avoid this outcome.

From corporate Singapore right down to individuals' career choices, failure is often seen as humiliating and a social taboo. We have national ranking for almost every possible category, including the most profitable companies, the school that has the most number of scholars, the most frequented restaurants and even hawker stalls. The media and the government are not shy in reporting the country's standing in international ranking and indexes, including ones that measure national economic performance and productivity rates. It is apparent **we do not believe in mediocrity**. It does seem to be weighing us down as feedback by international corporate employers reveal Singaporean employees to be very risk averse and it is possibly caused by us labelling people who fail – in school, in work and in business and by an education system that teaches students that there is a right and a wrong way to do things.

3. Those in the community who fail are seen as having reached a dead end and are treated somewhat harshly by national laws and policies, not being able to access resources and opportunities that can allow the individual to get back on their feet.

For example, an individual who have defaulted on repayment of debt before will find it difficult to get another loan from the bank or a financial services firm. Banks in Singapore also do not lend to persons with no assets and add on a premium to be levied on those who have defaulted in payment before. (<http://www.todayonline.com/Singapore/enable-those-who-fail-start-over>)

Once a person is declared a bankrupt, there is a possibility that he would be fired from his job. Given that he has to inform his potential employer of his financial status (when he applies for

a job), there is a high chance that employers would be apprehensive about hiring him. (<http://blog.moneysmart.sg/saving/bankrupt-in-singapore-what-are-the-consequences/>)

Part B. Show that the Singaporean society is now more open to giving people second chances as we recognise that failure is but a step towards attaining success

1. Today's tougher operating environment requires individuals who dare to take calculated risks and seek out new opportunities through innovation and an entrepreneurial spirit, which necessitates the community's and the individual's embracing of the possibility of failure.

To survive and succeed in the competitive global playing field, the Singapore society cannot afford to continue to stigmatise failure lest the fear of failure holds Singaporeans back from venturing out of their comfort zone to innovate or become entrepreneurs. This would put Singapore at risk of being left behind. In fact, the government feels there is a need for schools here to imbue students with technology skills and the Silicon Valley mindset of "fail fast, learn quickly". Very often, names of successful personalities such as JK Rowling, Jack Ma, Steve Jobs, Bill Gates are dropped to show that one needs not fear failure as they have gone on to achieve great success after perseverance. Schools are given leeway to design their own teaching and learning programme, and to remodel their assessment modes in the hope that examination scores stop dictating directions students take as they go about their learning. Laws governing what one can do and cannot do and by when were changed so that the fear of failure, in this case, financial ruin did not become a stumbling block to entrepreneurship. (https://www.nomurafoundation.or.jp/en/wordpress/wp-content/uploads/2014/09/20000127-28_Siow-Yue_Chia.pdf)

2. Changes in the education landscape meant that increased prominence and attention have been given to technical education and other less conventional routes which originally were seen as taken by people who are not able to meet up to the standards set by the community.

This no doubt has had the effect of altering Singaporeans' perception of failure for the young, which then brought about a change in mindset towards failure. 'Academic failure' is often seen as the inability to enter more prestigious institutions of study like junior colleges or universities or attain a reputable university degree. Those who choose to take alternative routes of study or alternative careers like artists, sportsmen etc. were also often not looked favourably upon in the past. Today, the vocational or technical education that was shunned by many, is now accorded more respect and significance by both the government as well as some people in our society as technical skills and work experience are becoming increasingly important today. Polytechnics have seen a surge in enrollment and ITEs are also viewed as a viable route for those who may not be so academically inclined but are capable in their own way and are not failures in life.

3. In a world that has been volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous, Singapore has no choice but to be engaged in more 'trial and error' sort of thinking, which would mean

that failure must now be accepted as a way to move forward amidst testing crises and emergencies.

From the global economic recessions in the last number of years, to the debilitating haze emanating from her neighbours, to the Covid-19 outbreak from 2020 till even currently, it has come to be realised that given the unprecedented urgency and severity of challenges facing the country, failures become a necessary process for the right decisions to be reached. Especially during the pandemic, the painful process the country went through as she took missteps after missteps when dealing with the initial panic grocery and food stuff buying, the ever present mongering of rumours and fake news of all manner, and the initially undetected and unreported outbreak in the foreign workers' dormitory, all went to show that striving for 100% efficacy in every thing we do, and trying one's level best to avoid failure is not the way forward. At the height of the pandemic, after the new variant Omicron was discovered, PM Lee Hsien Loong himself spoke about the need to have systems and processes that learn along the way, so that if any other medical crises were to occur again, Singapore will be in better stead.

Read: <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/full/10.1177/0275074020942454>